Lesson 23: Grammar: Passive Voice

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 2: Sentences and Paragraph Types · American History

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 6.4: Grammar Presentation-Passive Voice; 6.5: Applying Grammar to Reading; 6.6: Communication Practice.

In this lesson

You will learn how to form the passive voice in nine tenses, which verbs can be passive, and when to choose the passive instead of the active. Then you will find passive sentences in the reading "Japanese Relocation During World War II" and ask a critical question: when a history text uses the passive, who is the hidden performer? Passive voice is very common in academic textbooks, so recognizing and using it helps you read and write about research and history.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Tell active sentences from passive sentences.
- Form the passive with be (in the right tense) + past participle, with or without by + performer.
- Explain why only transitive verbs can be passive.
- Choose the passive when the receiver is more important or the performer is unknown.
- Find the hidden performer in a passive sentence in a history text.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
active voice	the subject is the performer of the verb	The boy ate the cookies.
passive voice	the subject is the receiver of the action: be + past participle	The cookies were eaten by the boy.
performer	the person or thing that does the action	by the boy
receiver	the person or thing that the action happens to	the cookies
direct object	the noun after a verb that receives the action	Sarina played the piano.
transitive verb	a verb that has a direct object; it can be passive	I drink coffee.
intransitive verb	a verb with no direct object; it cannot be passive	The student arrived early.
past participle	the third form of a verb	eaten, written, given, done

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
conjugate (v)	to change the form of a verb for its subject and tense	is, was, has been, will be
tense	the form of a verb that shows time	simple past, present perfect
critical reading	reading carefully and asking what a text shows and what it hides	Who are the performers, and why aren't they mentioned?

Rules and explanations

Active and passive

- **Active:** subject (performer) + verb + direct object (receiver). The boy ate the cookies.
- **Passive:** direct object (receiver) + be + past participle + (by + performer). The cookies were eaten by the boy.
- The be verb is conjugated for the tense. The by + performer part is not required: you can leave it out.
- Passive = be + **past participle**. Be + verb-ing is a progressive tense, and it is active: Patty is tutoring the student.

Only transitive verbs can be passive

The passive needs a direct object, so only transitive verbs can be passive.

- Transitive: I drink coffee. → Coffee is drunk. Sarina played the piano. → The piano was played by Sarina. They have done their homework. → Their homework has been done.
- Intransitive (no object, no passive): I slept. The accident happened. The student arrived early.

Verb tense and voice

Tense	Active	Passive
simple present	Patty tutors the student.	The student is tutored by Patty.
present progressive	Patty is tutoring the student.	The student is being tutored by Patty.
present perfect	Patty has tutored the student.	The student has been tutored by Patty.
simple past	Patty tutored the student.	The student was tutored by Patty.
past progressive	Patty was tutoring the student.	The student was being tutored by Patty.
past perfect	Patty had tutored the student.	The student had been tutored by Patty.
simple future	Patty will tutor the student.	The student will be tutored by Patty.
future (be going to)	Patty is going to tutor the student.	The student is going to be tutored by Patty.
future perfect	Patty will have tutored the student.	The student will have been tutored by Patty.

Negatives and questions work like other be sentences: The student was not tutored by Patty. Was the student tutored by Patty?

Which voice should you use?

1. Use the passive when the verb or the receiver is more important than the performer. Active: People eat black-eyed peas for New Year's Day. Passive: Black-eyed peas are eaten for New Year's Day. A verb with two objects has two passives: My son was offered a scholarship. OR A scholarship was offered to my son.
2. Use the passive when the performer is unknown: The bank was robbed last night. Thousands of innocent people were killed.

Passive voice and history: who is hidden?

When history is told in the passive voice, important performers are sometimes hidden. The writer focuses on the victims and protects the image of the performer: Native Americans were often relocated by force. (By whom?) When you read a passive sentence in a history text, ask: Who is the performer? Why is it not mentioned?

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic forms the passive by changing the vowels inside the verb, with no helping verb, so learners often leave out be: "Relocation centers situated many miles inland." English needs be + past participle: Relocation centers were situated many miles inland.

Practice

Exercise 3: Active or passive? Is the sentence a) active or b) passive? If the subject is "doing" the verb, the sentence is active.

1. The jury voted at the end of the trial.
2. Some jurors were told to leave at noon.
3. All the jurors were leaving the building when the reporters came in.
4. My sister Joan has been selected for jury two different times.
5. Were you given any information about that murder case?
6. Not every juror will be needed for the trial next week.

Exercise 4: Transitive or intransitive? Select all the sentences that can be changed into passive voice (sentences with a transitive verb and a direct object).

1. Ning does his homework every day.
2. The child screams too much.
3. Frances often helps her neighbors.
4. Levar has left his wallet in the classroom.
5. She wrote my favorite poem.

Exercise 5: Verb tense and voice. Complete each passive sentence with the be verb only, in the tense of the active sentence. Use the table.

1. Maya writes the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
2. Maya is writing the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
3. Maya has written the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
4. Maya wrote the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
5. Maya was writing the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
6. Maya had written the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
7. Maya will write the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
8. Maya is going to write the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.
9. Maya will have written the poem. The poem _____ written by Maya.

Exercise 6: Active to passive. Change the sentences to passive voice. Do not include the performer if it is unnecessary. Example: The US government "reserved" relatively small areas of land for Native Americans. → Small areas of land were "reserved" for Native Americans by the US government.

1. Maslow developed the theory.
2. Someone made my car in Japan.
3. People learn English around the world.
4. Workers will complete the project next week.
5. Students use computers to do homework.
6. Samuel F.B. Morse invented the telegraph.
7. The college has given three scholarships.

Exercise 7: Active or passive in the reading. These sentences are from "Japanese Relocation During World War II". Look for the receiver and the performer. Is each sentence a) active or b) passive?

1. The attack on Pearl Harbor also launched a rash of fear about national security, especially on the West Coast. (Paragraph 2)
2. In February 1942, just two months after Pearl Harbor, President Roosevelt, as commander-in-chief, issued Executive Order 9066. (Paragraph 2)
3. The eastern boundary of the military zone was an imaginary line along the rim of the Cascade Mountains. (Paragraph 3)
4. Within weeks, all persons of Japanese ancestry - whether citizens or enemy aliens, young or old, rich or poor - were ordered to assembly centers near their homes. (Paragraph 4)
5. Persons of Japanese ancestry in western Washington State were removed to the assembly center at the Puyallup Fairgrounds near Tacoma. (Paragraph 5)
6. In 1943 and 1944 the government assembled a combat unit of Japanese Americans for the European theater. (Paragraph 7)
7. One of the most stunning ironies in this episode of American civil liberties was articulated by an internee. (Paragraph 10)

Exercise 8: Critical reading. For each sentence from the Chapter 4 and 5 readings, explain why the performer is or is not included. If it is not included, say who the performer probably is. Write your answers, or discuss them with your tutor.

1. Over 4,000 Native Americans died from either starvation or disease while they were being relocated. (Life on Reservations, Paragraph 3)
2. Persons of Japanese ancestry in western Washington State were removed to the assembly center at the Puyallup Fairgrounds near Tacoma. (Japanese Relocation During World War II, Paragraph 5)
3. Persons who became troublesome were sent to a special camp at Tule Lake, California, where dissidents were housed. (Japanese Relocation, Paragraph 6)
4. ... the Japanese American community of Tacoma, Washington, had been sent to three different centers. (Japanese Relocation, Paragraph 8)
5. Mitsuye Endo is entitled to an unconditional release by the War Relocation Authority. (Japanese Relocation, Paragraph 9)

Exercise 10: New Year traditions (listening). Watch the video about New Year traditions around the world: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pxCswHrapP8. Complete the sentences with the passive voice. Listen first: the text with the answers is at the end of the Lesson 22 transcript ("Exercise-Listening Practice-Passive Voice"), so read it only to check.

1. Twelve grapes _____ to bring good luck. The grapes symbolize the 12 months in the year.
2. Negative energy _____ when every corner of the home _____ with a broom.
3. Purple and gold decorations _____ in the house to bring prosperity and health.
4. New clothes especially red ones _____ to attract prosperity and passion.
5. Donations _____ to those in need to make room for what the new year will bring.
6. Money _____ in shoes to show economic stability.
7. Water _____ out the window or door to let go of suffering, tears, or sorrow.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me about my favorite celebration (Exercise 11). Ask your questions in the passive, for example 'When is this event celebrated?' I will answer in the passive about food and drinks, clothes, activities, decorations and places."
- "Describe a living room before and after a makeover. I will say five things that have been done, in the passive, for example 'The window shutters were removed' (the book's example) or 'The walls have been painted.'" (This replaces Exercise 9, which uses pictures.)
- "Give me ten active sentences in different tenses. I will change each one to the passive and decide if the by-phrase is needed."
- "Ask me five questions about Executive Order 9066 that I must answer in the passive, for example 'Where were Japanese Americans sent?'"

Read aloud

- The cookies were eaten by the boy. (were = /wər/)
- The student is being tutored by Patty.
- Their homework has been done. (been = /bɪn/)
- Black-eyed peas are eaten for New Year's Day.
- My son was offered a scholarship. (was = /wəz/)
- Relocation centers were situated many miles inland, often in remote and desolate locales.

Writing task

Write a paragraph of 8-10 sentences about your favorite celebration (Exercise 11). Begin with a passive topic sentence, like the book's example: "Eid al-Fitr is celebrated after the month of Ramadan."

- Describe the food and drinks, clothes, activities, decorations and places.
- Use at least six passive verbs. Use the simple present for traditions (Special sweets are made ...) and the simple past for one memory (Last year, our house was decorated ...).
- Include the performer (by + noun) only when it is important.

Checklist:

- Does every passive verb have be + past participle (are made, not are make or made)?
- Is the be verb in the right tense and does it agree with its subject (sweets are, the house is)?
- Are the past participles correct (eaten, worn, given, thrown)?
- Did you use only transitive verbs in the passive (not "was happened")?
- Did you leave out "by + performer" when the performer is unknown or not important?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Active and Passive Voice: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=O6L7fW3Q4qI
- Active and Passive Voice (2): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AQNvhUrAn7o
- Active versus Passive Voice: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W1_IRU6zx9g
- How to use the Passive Voice-English Grammar Lesson: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nkAyggAM1q4

Answer key

Exercise 3. (book) 1. a 2. b 3. a (were leaving is the past progressive: be + verb-ing, active) 4. b 5. b 6. b

Exercise 4. (book) 1, 3, 4 and 5. Sentence 2 has no direct object: screams is intransitive.

Exercise 5. 1. is 2. is being 3. has been 4. was 5. was being 6. had been 7. will be 8. is going to be 9. will have been

Exercise 6. (book)

1. The theory was developed by Maslow.
2. My car was made in Japan.
3. English is learned around the world.
4. The project will be completed next week.
5. Computers are used to do homework.
6. The telegraph was invented by Samuel F. B. Morse.
7. Three scholarships have been given.

In 1 and 6 the performer is important (a famous person), so keep it. In 2 to 5 the performer (someone, people, workers, students) is unnecessary. In 7, "by the college" is also possible.

Exercise 7. (book) 1. a 2. a 3. a (was is a linking verb here: was + noun, no past participle) 4. b 5. b 6. a 7. b

Exercise 8. (example answer)

1. Not included. The performer is the U.S. government and its soldiers. The sentence focuses on the Native Americans who died and does not say who forced them to move.
2. Not included. The performer is the military (soldiers), following the president's Executive Order 9066. The focus is on the people who were removed.
3. Not included. The performer is the government agency that ran the camps (the War Relocation Authority, named in paragraph 9).
4. Not included. The performer is the government. The focus is on the community.
5. Included: the release is by the War Relocation Authority. The Supreme Court names the agency because that agency must release her.

Exercise 10. (book) 1. are eaten 2. is removed, is brushed 3. are hung 4. are worn 5. are given 6. is placed 7. is thrown

My notes